Sir Alexander Burnes (1805–41): Burnes was an energetic, high-spirited and resourceful young Highland Scot whose skill in languages won him swift promotion. He led two expeditions of exploration into Afghanistan and Central Asia in 1830–2 and 1836–8, both nominally commercial, but in reality political, gathering detailed intelligence for the Company. On the second expedition, the discovery of a rival Russian delegation also wooing Dost Mohammad of Kabul led Burnes to urge Calcutta to sign a treaty of friendship, but his advice was ignored and Lord Auckland decided instead to replace Dost Mohammad with the more pliable Shah Shuja. Burnes strongly opposed this course, but agreed to support it after he was offered a baronetcy and the position of deputy to the Envoy, Sir William Macnaghten. In Kabul, his talents were wasted as Macnaghten took sole control of the administration and he threw himself instead into the pursuit of the women of Afghanistan. In this way he made himself the hate figure he remains to this day in Afghanistan; and it was this, according to the Afghan accounts, that helped sparked the final fatal explosion in Kabul and his own gruesome death on 2 November.

Charles Masson (1800–53): After faking his own death and deserting his regiment during the siege of Bharatpur in 1826, Masson crossed the Indus and explored Afghanistan on foot. He became the first westerner to explore Afghanistan's archaeology, locating the remains of the great Bactrian city of Bagram and excavating Buddhist stupas. Somehow Claude Wade learned the secret of Masson's real identity as a deserter, and before long had blackmailed him into becoming an 'intelligencer', so ensuring a stream of regular and accurate reports from Afghanistan. Masson assisted Burnes during his 1837–8 negotiations with Dost Mohammad, but unlike Burnes failed to find a position in the subsequent invasion and occupation, despite knowing Afghanistan better than any other Englishman. He eventually made his way back to England where he died in poverty near Potters Bar in 1853 'of an uncertain disease of the brain'.

Brigadier General John Shelton of the 44th Foot (d. 1844): Shelton was a cantankerous, rude and boorish man who had lost his right arm in the Peninsular War. He was a rigid disciplinarian and known to be 'a tyrant to his regiment'. On arrival in Kabul he soon made himself disliked in the cantonment, quickly falling out with the gentle and gentlemanly Major-